

Text One

The Benefits of Positive Thinking - and How You Can Do More of It

adapted from an article by Jen Doll from an American website

In this passage, the writer identifies benefits of positive thinking and offers advice to improve your outlook on life.



Looking on the bright side doesn't always come naturally, but you can train your mind to seek it out - and that will do wonders for your health.

No doubt you've heard it before, or some version of it: 'Turn that frown upside down!'; 'Smile, you'll feel better!'; 'Stop focusing on how stressed you are and think about how blessed you are.' These little positive-thinking suggestions might be enough to make you want to punch a wall - look, no one wants to be told to smile, ever - but you might consider repeating the general message to yourself. Positivity has benefits that extend far beyond any Instagram meme¹. And even if you were born the total opposite of Pollyanna (a character in a novel who is excessively cheerful or optimistic), you can make positivity work for you. 5

So what is it, exactly? 'Positive thinking is all about having an open, optimistic viewpoint. It's the idea of seeing the silver lining on a bad day,' says Paraskevi Noulas, a clinical assistant professor of psychiatry at New York University. That doesn't mean you sweep your actual thoughts under the rug to make room for unicorns and rainbows. Instead, it's about viewing situations from a more well-rounded perspective. For example, when you're stressed out over your workload, take a deep breath, consider what you've already accomplished, and tell yourself you'll get the job done in the best way you can. 10 15

Shifting your mind-set can make you feel better and also lead to real health benefits. 'Research shows that positive thinking is an incredibly important and effective way to improve your mood, physical health, energy level, concentration, productivity and more,' says Noulas. 20

People who are positive have been found to be better at problem-solving and dealing with setbacks. They're more resilient. And positive thinking can open up creativity, help you connect better with others, and boost your overall well-being, too. Here, experts share a few simple ways to start seeing things in a sunnier light.

Build the Skill

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'You can't just pick up a violin and play,' points out Richard J. Davidson, director of the Center for Healthy Minds at the University of Wisconsin-Madison. Similarly, you can't just wake up and decide you're going to be positive. You need to practice summoning those feelings - and rehearsing works. Even short bursts done regularly - like appreciating a nice view or a lovely piece of art - can help retrain your mind to notice the good stuff all around you. Some other positivity-boosting tactics: list things you're grateful for at the end of each day or engage in simple meditation exercises. For example, you might imagine a crowd of people and acknowledge that we all share the same wish to be happy and free of suffering. Then mentally extend that wish to others.

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Spread Some Kindness

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One of the most powerful strategies to promote your own positivity, it turns out, is to be generous towards other people: Hold the elevator door for someone, send a handwritten note, pay for the person in line behind you at the coffee shop. A 2016 study found that performing acts of kindness was even more effective at boosting happiness than simply treating oneself. So instead of booking that spa day, try volunteering or better yet, do both. The more we are helpful to others, the better we feel about ourselves, says Noulas. 'Rather than waiting for good or positivity to come to you, take the initiative and create it for those around you. Then enjoy the ripple effect that unfurls as a result.'

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Flash a Grin

For a quick dose of positivity, try cracking a smile. A 2012 study conducted at the University of Kansas found that smiling reduced stress. And other research has shown that smiling is contagious.

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Nurture Your Relationships

Here's one more reason to prioritise quality time with your family and friends: Your social ties can colour how you experience life, says Vivian Sayas, an associate psychology professor at Cornell University. Her work includes a study in which people received a supportive text message from their partner right before a stressful event. 'Just getting a text increases positivity in the moment,' she says.

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It's OK to Get Mad, Too

Feeling angry on occasion can actually be helpful. 'Sometimes you need to be angry because you see injustice, and it makes you take action,' explains Sonja Lyubomirsky, a professor and vice-chair of psychology at the University of California. The key is knowing the difference between functional emotions - which help you improve your situation - and unproductive reactions, like road rage. 'The world is both a wonderful and terrible place,' Lyubomirsky notes. 'There are good and bad things. It's what you choose to put in front of you.'

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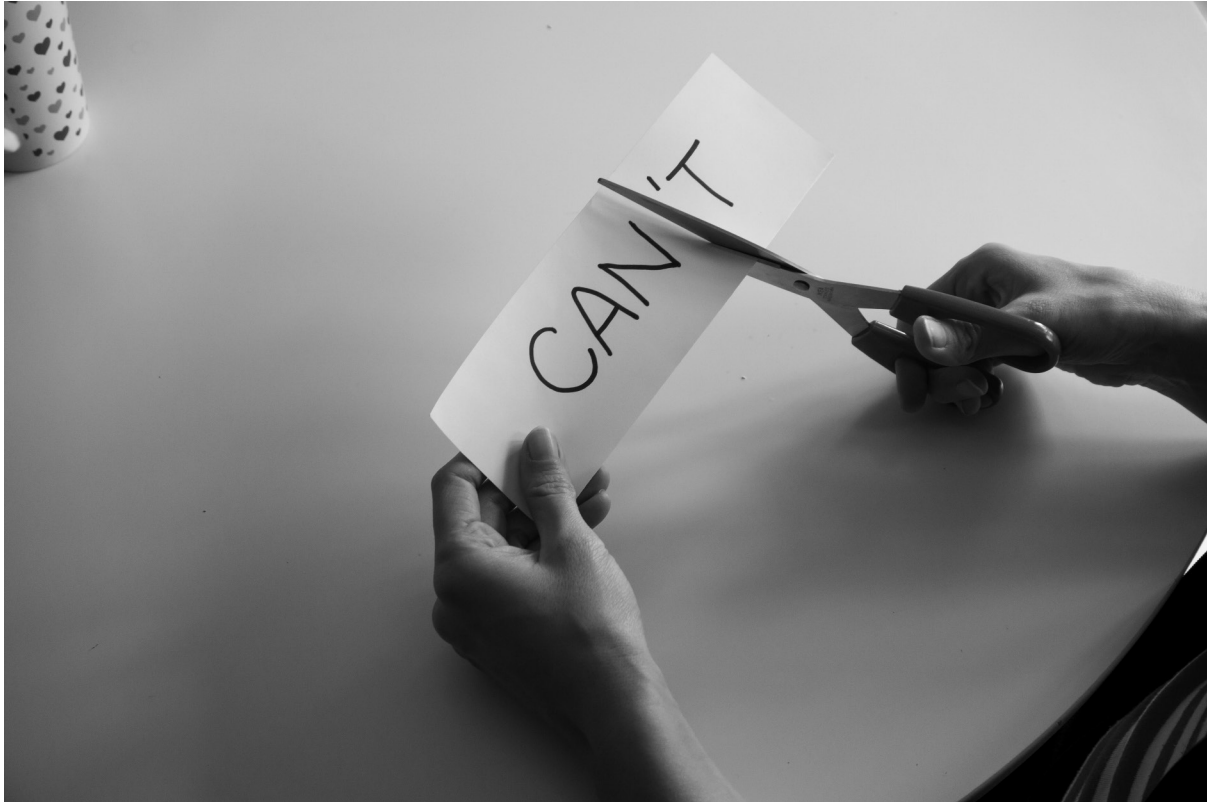
¹ *Instagram meme*: an image, video, piece of text, typically humorous in nature, that is copied and spread rapidly by Internet users

Text Two

Why Positive Thinking Doesn't (Always) Work

adapted from an article by Laura Newcomer

In this passage, the American writer suggests that negative thinking has some benefits.



The year is 2011. I'm living out of a duffel bag, sleeping on my friend's couch at night, dishwashing part-time at a pizza parlour because it's the only work I can find in northern Maine at the end of the summer, and holding in my hands a huge medical bill that I am unable to pay. Oh yeah, and I have pneumonia. I call my friend, and within two minutes I'm crying. She tells me, 'Look on the bright side.' I want to punch her in the face. Don't get me wrong. I love my friend, a lot (and I would never *actually* want to cause her any harm). But when I'm at my worst, I don't want anybody telling me to act my best.

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It turns out there's some science behind my feelings: A look at the research reveals positive thinking isn't always all it's cracked up to be. In fact, researchers are asking: What if embracing so-called 'negative' states like failure, pessimism, insecurity, and uncertainty actually has a positive outcome?

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It's Not All Rainbows and Unicorns

It's not until recently that people have started thinking of happiness as something everybody's entitled to all of the time. And in the headlong pursuit of ever-present positivity, we might be shooting ourselves in the feet. Constant positive thinking, some researchers say, means a person can never relax - because that's the moment a 'negative' thought might squirm its way to the surface. And insisting that 'everything works out' offers positive thinkers no back-up plan for when things don't.

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These criticisms are backed by a lot of research. One study found that when people think others expect them not to feel negative emotions, they end up feeling *more* negative

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emotions more frequently. Another study found that people with low self-esteem who repeated a positive self-statement ('I'm a lovable person') ended up feeling worse than people who didn't repeat the phrase. Some researchers have linked the pressure to 'think positive' to personal self-blame ('If I can't be happy, it must be my fault for not being positive enough').

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In fact, too much positive thinking can actually be a sign of a mood disorder, says Mark Banschick, a psychiatrist. People with bipolar disorder experience states of excessive positive thinking called 'mania' that can interfere with their experience of reality.

Though a typical person doesn't experience positivity at such a manic level, it *is* possible for the average person to get swept up by positive feelings, lose their judgment, and do something they wouldn't normally do. Positive thinking can also become a way of avoiding necessary action. People might say 'everything's fine' even when it's not - it's a way of convincing ourselves we're doing something about a given situation (a bad job, a looming deadline, an issue with a partner or friend) without actually doing anything.

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'People who use positive thinking as a defence are trying not to feel anxious when they should,' Banschick says. Some amount of anxiety is often necessary for motivating us to act in certain situations. Covering up this anxiety with a cheery face can actually make our situation worse because we're less likely to address the underlying issue. But the sooner we take action, the less likely anxiety is to interfere with whatever it is we're trying to do, says Julie Norem, professor of psychology and author of *The Positive Power of Negative Thinking*.

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The Benefits of Being a Pessimist

So some level of negativity might actually be good for us. One study found that people in negative moods can produce better quality and more persuasive arguments than people in a positive mood. Negative moods can also improve memory and mental accuracy, and other research suggests that negative thinking might prompt us to think more carefully. In light of these findings, many researchers are criticising what they see as exaggerated claims from the pro-positivity camp, and standing behind the benefits of negative thinking. By preparing for the worst, there's a chance we actually decrease our suffering down the road. In contrast, trying to 'correct' negative thoughts can actually intensify them.

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The effectiveness of positive thinking is also highly dependent on individual factors like anxiety, coping mechanisms, and belief systems, so each person has to find what works for her or him. But regardless of a person's disposition, researchers suggest it might be better to acknowledge negative emotions instead of denying them - and then let them pass.

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The Takeaway

We're certainly not recommending that everyone become a sourpuss for life. Just like negative thinking, positive thinking has its proven benefits, both physically and psychologically. The trick is finding the balance between being optimistic and being realistic, Banschick says. In other words: Stop and smell the roses, but first check for dog poo on the sidewalk beneath your feet.

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